

LAURA PÉREZ CERVERA

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EMPLOYMENT

2025-present **Assistant Professor (Professora Lectora)**, Departament d'Economia, Universitat Rovira i Virgili

RESEARCH FIELDS

Primary Field : Applied Microeconomics

Secondary Fields: Political Economy, Development Economics, Media Economics

EDUCATION

2019-2025	PhD in Economics , Queen Mary University of London <u>Thesis Title</u> : Empirical Essays in Political Economy <u>Thesis Advisors</u> : Marco Manacorda and Andrea Tesei
2023 (Feb-May)	Research Visit , Vancouver School of Economics (UBC) <u>Host Advisor</u> : Claudio Ferraz
2018-2019	MRes in Economics , Queen Mary University of London
2017-2018	MSc in Economics , Barcelona School of Economics
2016-2017	BSc in Economics , Universitat Pompeu Fabra
2012-2016	BSc in Business Administration and Management , Universitat Pompeu Fabra

WORKING PAPERS

“Affirming a Racial Divide? The Political Consequences of Affirmative Action in Brazil” (JMP)

Abstract: This paper investigates whether affirmative action policies, by emphasizing group identity in resource allocation, can polarize voters along identity lines. I explore this potential unintended consequence of affirmative action by studying the implementation of the first nationwide racial affirmative action policy in Brazil, the Law of Quotas, which mandated that half of all admission seats in public federal universities be reserved for historically underrepresented groups, including non-White students. To assess the local effects of the policy, I construct a municipality-level exposure measure based on pre-policy enrolment patterns and the expansion of reserved seats across federal universities. My findings reveal a significant increase in non-White student enrolment, without necessarily reducing enrolment opportunities for White

students within the same municipalities. Using geographically granular voting data, electorates' demographics, and an automated machine-learning model trained to approximate candidates' racial identity based on official photographs, I find that the reform polarized Brazilian legislative elections along racial lines. This effect manifested as an increase in support for left-wing Black candidates among the non-White electorate and a rise in support for conservative candidates among White voters.

“High-Speed Internet and Government Responsiveness: Evidence from U.S. Federal Spending” - Submitted

Abstract: This paper studies how broadband Internet diffusion affects government responsiveness by examining the allocation of U.S. federal spending across municipalities between 1999 and 2010. Using proximity to the Interstate Highway System as a cost-based instrument for broadband deployment, I find that broadband expansion increases discretionary spending, the component most responsive to political incentives, while leaving mandatory spending unaffected. Broadband diffusion also increases campaign contributions in presidential and congressional elections, partly driven by the entry of new donors. These findings suggest that broadband diffusion strengthens electoral incentives and shifts public spending toward domains where elected officials retain allocation discretion.

WORK IN PROGRESS

“Racial Disparities in Political Representation: Evidence from Brazil, 2006-2022”

Abstract: This paper examines the determinants of racial political representation in Brazil from 2006 to 2022, focusing on supply-side factors. To address data limitations on the disclosure of candidates' race, I train an Automated Machine Learning model for image classification applied to over 1.5 million candidate photos. The analysis reveals that non-White candidates, although numerically superior, face significant electoral disadvantages compared to White candidates. This disparity persists across all election levels and is influenced by differential party endorsements, particularly campaign funding. I also identify inequalities in education and wealth among candidates, likely reflecting the structural racial inequalities in the country. Despite recent improvements in non-White representation, pronounced disparities remain, especially in higher political offices.

“The Effect of Internet Expansion on the Political Representation of Minorities in the United States”
(with Alessandra Moresi)

CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

- 2026 Women in Political Economics Workshop (*scheduled*); EEA-ESEM Congress (*declined*)
- 2025 SAEe 2025; 11th IEB Workshop on Political Economy; 5th Early Career Workshop in Quantitative Political Economy (King's College of London); Universitat Rovira i Virgili; LEAP Bocconi University; University of Stuttgart; Institute for Fiscal Studies
- 2024 4th Winter Workshop of the Catalan Economic Society, 17th UniTo-Collegio Carlo Alberto PhD Workshop; LACEA-RIDGE Forum in Political Economy; EEA MinE Research Virtual Sessions; 6th QMUL Economics and Finance PhD Workshop; Applied Microeconomics Internal Seminar, Queen Mary University of London

- 2023 EEA/ESEM Congress; PSE-CEPR Policy Forum; 1st EUI PhD Workshop; RES PhD Conference; 11th Warwick PhD Conference; Brown Bag Dev/Pol Vancouver School of Economics; Applied Microeconomics Internal Seminar, Queen Mary University of London
- 2022 CAGE Summer School “New Research in Political Economy”; Applied Microeconomics Internal Seminar, Queen Mary University of London

GRANTS, SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

- 2026 AEI Proyectos de Generación de Conocimiento. Project: *The Interplay between Cultural Values, Telecommunication Technologies and Public Policies* (PID2025-174339OB-I00). Research Team (PI: Susana Iranzo). Amount: €30,000
- 2025 Honorary Mention in the IDB Young Economist Award, Inter-American Development Bank
- 2024 Undergraduate Teaching Excellence Award, Queen Mary University of London
- 2023 Funding for Research Visits, Queen Mary University of London
- 2022 UKRI ESRC LISS-DTP Student-Led Activity Funding
- 2019-2022 UKRI ESRC LISS-DTP PhD Studentship
- 2018-2022 MRes./Ph.D. Scholarship, Queen Mary University of London

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- 2025 Research Assistant for Marta Cota, Nova School of Business & Economics
- 2019-2023 Research Assistant for Professors Marco Manacorda and Andrea Tesei, Queen Mary University of London
- 2017 Research Assistant for Professor Marta Reynal-Querol, Universitat Pompeu Fabra

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- 2026-2027 Lecturer, Universitat Rovira i Virgili
Introduction to Economics, Economics (Law), Tourism Sectors and Systems
- 2025-2026 Lecturer, Universitat Rovira i Virgili
Principles of Applied Economics, Economics (Law), Final-Year Thesis
- 2024-2025 Teaching Assistant, Queen Mary University of London
Principles of Economics, Behavioural Economics
- 2023-2024 Teaching Assistant, Queen Mary University of London
Labour Economics, Behavioural Economics
- 2022-2023 Teaching Assistant, Queen Mary University of London
Principles of Economics, Economics and Finance in Action

LANGUAGE & IT SKILLS

Software: Stata, Python, ArcGIS, Google VertexAI, R, Matlab, Latex

Languages: Spanish (Native), Catalan (Native), English (Fluent), Italian (Intermediate), Portuguese (Beginner)

SERVICE & OTHER RELEVANT POSITIONS

2026-present	Organizer Departmental External Seminars, Universitat Rovira i Virgili
2025-present	Organizer ECO-SOS Internal Seminars, Universitat Rovira i Virgili
2018-2024	PhD Cohort Representative, Queen Mary University of London
2019-2022	Organizer QMUL Applied Microeconomics Internal Seminars
2021-2022	Organizer 4 th QMUL Economics and Finance Workshop
2020-2021	Scientific Committee 3 rd QMUL Economics and Finance Workshop